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Research and Content Gathering – Thread & Tide.

Organization and Industry Research

Thread & Tide is a fictional clothing retail store aimed mainly at teenagers and young adults. The store will focus on affordable and fashionable clothing, including tops, jeans, dresses, jackets and accessories.

Research shows that online shopping is an important part of South African retail. The 2026 Stitch Consumer Payments Report found that 78.1% of surveyed consumers buy clothing and apparel online, making it the most purchased online category in the report. It also found that 74.6% of respondents shop on brand websites (Stitch, 2026). This supports the idea of giving Thread & Tide a strong online presence where customers can view products before deciding whether to purchase them.

The U.S. International Trade Administration (2026) also identifies clothing and apparel as a leading e-commerce category in South Africa. The source notes that South African consumers are price-sensitive and often use online platforms to compare prices and look for product recommendations. This is relevant to Thread & Tide because the store is intended to offer affordable and fashionable clothing.

Target Audience Research

The main target audience for Thread & Tide will be teenagers and young adults who are interested in current fashion trends but are also looking for reasonably priced clothing.

The website should therefore focus on clear product images, simple categories and easy navigation. This is particularly important because South African internet use is strongly influenced by mobile devices, with increased internet access among younger groups through smartphones and affordable mobile data (International Trade Administration, 2026).

The website will therefore be planned so that customers can quickly find products without having to move through unnecessary pages.

Competitor Research

I researched established clothing retailers to see how existing websites organize their products and present information to customers.

H&M was useful because its South African store information separates products into categories such as Ladies, Men, Kids, Denim and Accessories (H&M, 2026). This shows how clothing retailers can organize a wide range of products into clear categories, which can make browsing easier for customers.

Cotton On was also researched as another clothing retailer. Its website provides customers with different ways to search for products, including searching by product name, category, attributes and color (Cotton On, 2026). This helped influence the decision to organize Thread & Tide's products into clear categories rather than displaying everything on one page.

Website Content Research

Based on the research, Thread & Tide should provide basic information that customers would expect when browsing clothing online. Each product should include a product name, image, price, category and short description. Where appropriate, information such as available sizes and colours can also be included.

The proposed product categories are:

- Tops
- Bottoms
- Dresses
- Jackets
- Accessories

These categories are based on patterns seen on established clothing websites but have been simplified to suit the smaller Thread & Tide concept.

Research Findings

The research shows that Thread & Tide would benefit from a website that focuses on simple product browsing, clear categories, strong product images and easy to find information. Clothing is already a huge online shopping category in South Africa, while established retailers such as H&M demonstrate the value of organizing products into clear sections (Stitch, 2026; H&M, 2026).

References

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